work for national unity, perpetuation of the state, and work for the consolidation and strengthening of sovereignty. In the end, overwhelming loyalty to the military remained in place.

General Saw Maung was the chairman of SLORC. The essential platform of the regime was: restoration of law, order, peace and tranquility; providing security; assist the population regarding food, clothing, and shelter; and the eventual fulfillment of multiparty elections. The Pyithu Hluttaw and council of ministers were quickly abolished. The previous constitution was no longer relevant. The junta would include 19 high-ranking members of the military. The key subordinates to Saw Maung included Than Shwe (deputy chief of staff) and Khin Nyunt (director of defense services intelligence). It was clear that all 19 members of SLORC were Ne Win loyalists. It was apparent to all unbiased observers that the event of September 18 was a phony coup staged to reestablish clear military control in Burma.

Resistance to the military takeover was quickly destroyed. The tatmadaw was very organized and efficiently brutal. Opposition leaders were arrested and the military fired on pagodas and homes of suspected sympathizers. Strike centers and the free media were closed down. Curfews were imposed and public gatherings outlawed. Any bureaucrats who had been involved in pro-democracy organizations were fired and many were arrested. In order to conceal their real intentions, the tatmadaw claimed that the coup was a “temporary mandate” that would end following the elections.

TIGHTENING THE NOOSE: SLORC IN POWER

Burmese civil society was brutality crushed by SLORC in the late summer of 1989. However, it became apparent quickly that SLORC planned on keeping the schedule for multiparty elections. The election commission remained in place, as the regime believed that by holding the elections, legitimacy would be gained. Second, Burma was in desperate need of foreign assistance. It quickly became apparent to the regime that Aung San Suu Kyi's popularity and prestige, especially with powerful Western powers, was going to challenge the junta's claim to govern.

On November 8, the government press agency announced that the elections would be held on May 27, 1990. The regime would monitor all electoral activities including rallies, media, and publications. By February,